forged broad consensus on various aspects of India's foreign policy, and succeeding governments seemed reluctant to carve new paths in external engagement. The first major change in Indian foreign policy, away from Nehruvianism, occurred only after the end of the cold war and the collapse of the Soviet Union.

From the 1990s onward, India started building closer ties with Western powers, especially the United States. Economics has now become a major factor in Indian foreign policy though India's 'Look East' policy also invokes historical and cultural ties with East and South-East Asia. Still, Indians do not want to appear to have abandoned non-alignment, which remains part of India's foreign policy rhetoric.

It is almost as if new beliefs are being explained as an extension of the old religion. For example, in 2012, a group of leading Indian analysts published a policy brief titled 'Non-Alignment 2.0: A Foreign and Strategic Policy for India in the 20th Century', outlining the need for India to maintain its strategic autonomy, remain an example to the world and build its economy. The report insisted on describing India's new post-cold-war paradigm as a continuum of non-alignment during the cold war. No wonder then that India's emerging commonality of strategic interests with the United States coincides with its leaders still religiously attending annual sessions of the virtually defunct Non-Aligned Movement.

If major strands in India's contemporary foreign policy are to be classified along the lines of Walter Russell Mead's classification of schools in US foreign policy thinking, at least four trends can be readily identified: Imperial, Messianic Idealism, Realism and Isolationism.

The 'Imperial' school of thought draws primarily from the most recent pre-Independence experience of decision making known to India, the period of the British Raj. For this outlook, India is the centre and Delhi knows